

ISO 9001 Certification Checklist for UK SMEs

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How to use this checklist

Work through each section before your Stage 2 certification audit. Every item marked **Required** must be evidenced — not just documented, but demonstrably operating. Items marked **Recommended** are best practice that auditors will look for. Tick each box as you confirm it is in place.

1. Context and Scope

Item	Status	✓
Organisational context documented Internal and external issues relevant to quality and the QMS scope are identified and documented (Clause 4.1).	Required	☐
Interested parties identified Customers, regulators, and other stakeholders with quality-relevant requirements are listed with their specific needs (Clause 4.2).	Required	☐
QMS scope formally defined The scope states which products, services, sites, and processes are included, with justification for any exclusions (Clause 4.3).	Required	☐
Scope reflects operational reality The scope on the certificate matches what the business actually does — remote workers, outsourced functions, and satellite operations are accounted for.	Required	☐

2. Leadership and Policy

Item	Status	✓
Quality policy approved and communicated Policy is signed by top management, includes a commitment to continual improvement, and has been communicated to all relevant staff (Clause 5.2).	Required	■
Quality roles and responsibilities assigned Named individuals are responsible for QMS performance. Responsibilities are documented (Clause 5.3).	Required	■
Top management demonstrably involved Auditors will interview senior leadership. They must be able to discuss quality objectives and demonstrate involvement in the QMS without being coached (Clause 5.1).	Required	■
Management review conducted and minuted At least one formal management review covering the inputs required by Clause 9.3 has taken place, with minutes retained as evidence.	Required	■

3. Planning

Item	Status	✓
Risks and opportunities identified A documented process for identifying and addressing risks and opportunities relevant to the QMS and its intended outcomes is in place (Clause 6.1).	Required	■
Quality objectives set and measurable Objectives are documented, measurable, monitored, and have plans for how they will be achieved (Clause 6.2).	Required	■
Change management process in place Planned changes to the QMS are managed in a controlled manner with consideration of consequences and resources (Clause 6.3).	Recommended	■

4. Documentation and Records

Item	Status	✓
Quality policy documented A current, approved quality policy is available as documented information.	Required	■
Quality objectives documented Objectives are formally recorded with targets, methods, responsibilities, and timescales.	Required	■
Process documentation proportionate to organisation The extent of documented information reflects the organisation's size, complexity, and competence of personnel (Clause 7.5).	Required	■
Competence records maintained Records of education, training, skills, and experience are held for personnel whose work affects quality (Clause 7.2).	Required	■
Calibration records maintained If measurement equipment is used to provide confidence in results, calibration records are maintained (Clause 7.1.5).	Required (if applicable)	■
Document control process operating Documents are reviewed, approved, version-controlled, and outdated versions are withdrawn from use (Clause 7.5.3).	Required	■

5. Internal Audit

Item	Status	✓
Audit programme documented A planned audit programme covering all QMS processes and requirements over a defined period is in place (Clause 9.2).	Required	■
Internal audit conducted At least one complete internal audit cycle has been completed before the Stage 2 audit, with results documented.	Required	■
Audit tests effectiveness, not just existence The audit evaluates whether processes are effectively implemented, not just whether documents exist. Process-based auditing against real transactions is required.	Required	■
Auditors are objective and impartial Internal auditors do not audit their own work. Independence is documented.	Required	■
Audit findings addressed All nonconformities identified during internal audit have corrective actions assigned with target dates and evidence of completion.	Required	■

6. Nonconformity and Corrective Action

Item	Status	✓
Nonconformity process documented and operating A process for identifying, recording, and responding to nonconformities — including customer complaints — is in place and evidenced (Clause 10.2).	Required	■
Root cause analysis conducted Corrective actions address root causes, not just symptoms. Evidence of root cause analysis is retained.	Required	■
Corrective action effectiveness verified Actions are verified as effective after implementation. The verification step is documented.	Required	■
Nonconformity log maintained A log of nonconformities and corrective actions is maintained and available for auditor review.	Required	■

7. Performance and Continual Improvement

Item	Status	✓
Customer satisfaction monitored A process for monitoring customer perceptions of the degree to which requirements have been met is in place and producing results (Clause 9.1.2).	Required	■
QMS performance analysed and evaluated Data from monitoring and measurement activities is analysed to evaluate QMS performance and identify improvement opportunities (Clause 9.1.3).	Required	■
Continual improvement evidenced At least one demonstrable improvement to the QMS based on analysis of performance data, audit results, or management review is available (Clause 10.3).	Required	■
KPIs or quality metrics tracked Quantitative measures — defect rates, on-time delivery, customer complaint frequency — are tracked and reviewed at management review.	Recommended	■

The five most common reasons UK businesses fail their ISO 9001 Stage 2 audit

1. Top management cannot demonstrate involvement — the QMS is delegated entirely to one person who is not a director.
2. Quality objectives are not measurable — "improve customer satisfaction" without a target or measurement method is not an objective.
3. Process records are backdated before the audit — auditors check dates and can usually tell.
4. Internal audit only checks documents, not whether processes are actually followed.
5. Corrective actions close the finding without addressing the root cause — the same problem recurs.

Need help getting ISO 9001 certified?

Anacruses Associates provides fixed-fee ISO 9001 consultancy for UK businesses — from gap analysis through to certification audit support. Every client works directly with Rob Pragnell, CQI/IRCA certified Lead Auditor.

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